



Rumi

Seeking the Beloved

Translated by Nader Khalili



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English version © Nader Khalili

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Rumi

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Foreword

The name Mowlana Jalaluddin Rumi stands for love and ecstatic flight into the infinite. Rumi is one of the great spiritual masters and poetical geniuses of mankind and was the founder of the Mawlawi Sufi order, a leading mystical brotherhood of Islam.

Rumi was born in Wakhsh (Tajikistan) under the administration of Balkh in 30 September 1207 to a family of learned theologians. Escaping the Mongol invasion and destruction, Rumi and his family travelled extensively in Asia, went on pilgrimage to Mecca and finally settled in Konya, Anatolia, then part of Seljuk Empire.

When his father Bahauddin Valad passed away, Rumi succeeded him as professor in religious sciences. Rumi 24 years old, was an already accomplished scholar in religious sciences and was well respected amongst fellow scholars.

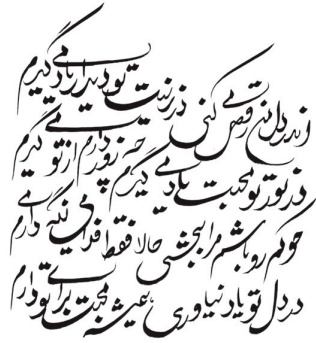
He was introduced to the mystical path by a wandering dervish, Shamsuddin of Tabriz. His love and his sorrow at the death of Shams found their expression in a surge of music, dance and lyric poems, Divani Shamsi Tabrizi. Rumi is the author of a six-volume didactic epic work, the Mathnawi, called the 'Koran in Persian' by Jami, and discourses, Fihi ma Fihi, written to introduce his disciples to metaphysics.

If there is any general idea underlying Rumi's poetry, it is the absolute love of God. His influence on thought, literature and all forms of aesthetic expression in the world of Islam cannot be overrated.

Mevlana Jalaluddin Rumi died on December 17, 1273. Men of five faiths followed his bier. That night was named Sebul Arus (Night of Union). Ever since, the Mawlawi dervishes have kept that date as a festival.

These poems have been translated by the late Nader Khalili. Born in Iran and educated as an architect, Khalili died in 2008. Inspired by the mystical poetry of Rumi (whose work he studied and translated from an early age), he had a great love for these poems. His architecture was influenced by the poetry, distilled from the timeless principles of this universe and its timeless materials—the elements of earth, air, water, and fire, and has been described as “Poetry crystallized into structure.”

This book is a tribute both to Khalili and to Rumi. As a native speaker of Persian as well as a master of English poetry, Khalili's translations capture much of the colour of the literal translations, while maintaining an immediacy frequently lost in translated poetry.



The Guest House

This being human is a guest house.
Every morning a new arrival.
A joy, a depression, a meanness,
some momentary awareness comes
as an unexpected visitor.

Welcome and entertain them all!
Even if they're a crowd of sorrows,
who violently sweep your house
empty of its furniture,
still, treat each guest honorably.
He may be clearing you out
for some new delight.

The dark thought, the shame, the malice,
meet them at the door laughing,
and invite them in.

Be grateful for whoever comes,
because each has been sent
as a guide from beyond.